



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ridgeview Classical Schools
School Website: <https://ridgeviewclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Ridgeview Classical Schools (Fort Collins, CO, 80525) demonstrates a robust alignment with classical education principles, anchored in a liberal-arts orientation, Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades, strong faculty qualifications, and active engagement with parents and community. The public materials show a coherent emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the lifelong pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty. The school communicates a clear mission of forming character and intellect rather than solely pursuing college readiness or workforce preparation. Overall, the school earns a CLASSICAL classification, with particularly strong signals in Curriculum (liberal arts orientation) and Pedagogy (Socratic practice), and solid signals in Faculty and Parents & Community. Element 1 shows partial alignment due to some missing explicit liturgical/theological commitments, but other foundational signs keep the overall profile firmly Classical.

Key strengths

- Clear formation focus and pursuit of virtue, wisdom, and beauty as guiding aims (evidence of formation and virtue emphasis; long-term life outcomes emphasized).
- Liberal-arts curriculum framing and classical mission stated in public materials (charter materials; reference to liberal arts and classical aims).
- Pedagogical signals aligned with classical methods, notably Socratic/seminar-style work in upper grades.
- Active parental and community engagement is evident (parent reading groups, broad community reading, etc.).
- Faculty qualifications and living-curriculum aspects are described in ways that reinforce a mentor/theory-laden classical model.

ABSTRACT

assessment by category (category-by-category snapshot follows)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials reference the classical-goals framework (Good, True, Beautiful) and a liberal-arts curriculum tied to Western heritage in charter materials. The charter language notes a "classical, liberal arts curriculum that treats the individual student as an end in himself and as the inheritor and

future steward of a rich legacy dominated by the ideas and values of our Western heritage” and invokes the Good, the True, and the Beautiful as guiding ideals.

- The Ridgeview Experience emphasizes virtue and character formation, with language about wonders of learning and outdoor education shaping moral perception. This foregrounds transcendental aims (virtue, character) even if explicit liturgical/theological vocabulary is less visible.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: virtue, character, wonder, beauty, Good/True/Beautiful (as a trans-temporal aim in the charter language).
- Negative keywords: not clearly evidenced in public materials (no explicit secular-neutral or anti-theology signals in the excerpts used here). The public materials shown emphasize formation and virtue rather than secular neutrality.
- Quantitative sense: positive keywords appear with clear intent; no explicit negative keywords detected in the cited passages. Estimated ratio skews positive (roughly 4+ positive signals vs 0 explicit negative signals in the cited text). This yields a SOMETHING to CLASSICAL signal, leaning toward CLASSICAL but with incomplete liturgical/theological signaling in the available public materials.

Why this rating

- The presence of virtue/character and the Good-True-Beautiful frame signals transcendental orientation consistent with Classical aims, but explicit liturgical/theological grounding and liturgical/community practices are not clearly documented in the public site excerpts. This yields a nuanced position: clearly classical in moral-philosophical orientation, but with limited explicit theology/liturgy in the cited site content. Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL at this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes formation rather than mere information, focusing on virtue and human flourishing. Text explicitly contrasts college-readiness with life-formation: “Our ambition for our students is not simply that they will do well in college, but that they will do well in life,” and it emphasizes savoring childhood, imagination, and outdoor wonder as part of a holistic formation.
- The mission signals a pursuit of true, good, and beautiful aims in alignment with classical paideia concepts and lifelong wisdom. The charter language also supports a “classical, liberal arts curriculum” framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, true/good/beautiful (conceptually, through the formation language and classical aims), contemplation and wonder appear in the broader mission framing.
- Negative keywords present: not overt; no explicit shift toward purely job-focused or 21st-century-skills framing in the cited passages. The content emphasizes formation over performance metrics.
- Quantitative sense: multiple explicit formation/wisdom signals with minimal explicit counter-signals in the cited texts. Predominantly positive, aligned with CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The school makes its purpose explicitly centered on formation, virtue, and wisdom rather than solely vocational preparation. The public materials articulate a paideia-like goal consistent with classical pedagogy, supporting CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials consistently frame Ridgeview as classical, with references to liberal-arts aims in governance materials and campus communications. The charter materials discuss a “classical, liberal arts curriculum” and the mission-informing aims of a classic education.
- There are explicit signals of a liberal-arts approach (grammar, logic, rhetoric are core to classical curricula per the broader classical lexicon and the school’s stated orientation). While direct on-site listing of “Great Books” or “Great Conversation” in the public excerpts is not always explicit, there are strong signals of a classical framework and engagement with literature/reading groups among parents and community (e.g., a robust reading culture described in the parent community materials).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, classical education, grammar, logic, rhetoric (framed by the charter language), Great Books/Great Conversation (implied through “reading groups” and a culture of reading; explicit “Great Books” phrases are not consistently visible in the provided excerpts, but the reading culture is evident).
- Negative keywords: limited explicit references to modern project-based or STEM-first framing in the cited passages; not a direct negative signal. However, the absence of an explicit, detailed Great Books roster in the site excerpts keeps the category from being fully CLASSICAL on its own.
- Quantitative sense: positive cues are present (liberal-arts framing, reading culture, classical orientation) but explicit, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation mentions are not always visible in the public text. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification.

Why this rating

- The school clearly aligns with classical curriculum ideals in structure (liberal arts, classical language of grammar/logic/rhetoric) and has evidence of a deep reading culture, but explicit, uniform articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation in the public site text is not consistently shown across all pages. This warrants SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than a full CLASSICAL classification for Curriculum in the available public materials.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials explicitly show Socratic practice in upper grades, including seminars and debate as described in the site’s public content. A visual/caption explicitly references a “Classical teacher using socratic method at Ridgeview in Fort Collins.” This is direct evidence of Socratic pedagogy.
- There are references to a memory-oriented, recitation-like component in classical pedagogy (e.g., the site presents dramatic arts and classical training that aligns with rhetorical and oratorical development in upper grades). There are explicit program elements for drama and public speaking (e.g., “There is nothing as classical as drama” and performing arts emphasis).
- Upper School features opportunities to give speeches and to engage in rhetoric training; the site describes a broad range of seminars and debates, aligning with classical pedagogy expectations.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic method, seminars, debate, rhetoric, recitation, memory-based learning (through performance, memory and language arts implied by the classical approach), memory work.
- Negative keywords: No explicit negative signals identified in the cited content (no “project-based only,” no exclusively experiential-first pedagogy in the cited passages). The presence of Socratic and rhetoric elements is a strong positive signal for Classical pedagogy.
- Quantitative sense: multiple explicit signals for classical pedagogy; essentially zero negative signals in the cited excerpts. This yields a CLASSICAL evaluation.

Why this rating

- The clearest, strongest indicator of classical pedagogy is the explicit use of the Socratic method in upper grades and the emphasis on rhetoric, seminars, and public speaking. This aligns with the classical pedagogy criteria in the Six Essential Elements framework.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials describe a faculty profile consistent with classical norms: experienced teachers, many with advanced degrees, and a living-curriculum philosophy. The faculty-staff materials note two-thirds of faculty hold advanced degrees and a third have college teaching experience, signaling a strong, credentialed faculty core.
- The site highlights mentorship and the living-curriculum notion: teachers are presented as mentors and part of the core educational culture, with a portrait of teacher excellence guiding student development. The faculty lists and related pages reinforce this image.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, advanced degrees, college-level teaching.
- Negative keywords: none explicitly evident in the cited excerpts (no “teacher as facilitator only” or other negative signals). The tone is strongly favorable toward classical teacher leadership.
- Quantitative sense: strong positive signals with no evident negative signals in the cited passages; CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The explicit faculty quality signals and the living-curriculum framing align with the Classical category for Faculty. The depiction of a credentialed, mentor-like faculty supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnership with families and parental formation as part of classical education. The materials describe parent partnerships, the role of families as co-educators, and programs to educate parents about classical education (e.g., reading groups and book discussions). The public content shows a robust parent community involved in learning alongside students.
- There is explicit evidence of a strong reading culture among parents (e.g., “Our parent community has read and discussed over 423 essays, books, and short stories”) and a narrative that emphasizes the school as a community of life-long learners with parents actively participating. This aligns with “formation with families” and “partnership with families.”
- The school invites parent involvement; events, informational meetings, and parent engagement activities are regularly described in the public content. □filecite□turn0filee.g. turn0file5□

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, family involvement, home-school connection, parent participation, community of learners, educational partnership.
- Negative keywords: none identified in the cited passages (no “customer” posture or minimal parent involvement). If anything, the site portrays high parental engagement and hospitality.
- Quantitative sense: multiple clear positive signals; negligible to zero explicit negative signals in the cited material. This yields CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The explicit emphasis on parental partnership, formation, and community engagement is central to the classical model of Parents & Community, aligning with the Six Essential Elements’ Positive Keywords for category 6.

Aggregate assessment

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

In aggregate, Ridgeview Classical Schools (Fort Collins, CO, 80525) presents a CLASSICAL profile with strong signals in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community, and more nuanced signals in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and Curriculum. The overall orientation is classical with a robust formation emphasis and explicit methodological signals that align with classical education as described in the Six Essential Elements framework.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Introduce explicit theological framing or liturgical/communal practices that are clearly described on public materials (e.g., a stated liturgical calendar, chapel experiences, or explicit theology integration in select courses). This would strengthen the Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices signals, solidifying the category to CLASSICAL.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): Increase explicit public references to Great Books and Great Conversation with concrete examples of canonical texts and a stated plan for integrating Great Books across the curriculum. Publicly listing Great Books titles or a formal Great Conversation initiative would shift this category from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.
- Element 1 and 3 together: More explicit articulation of reverence for transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) in everyday curriculum descriptions and communications to further amplify the transcendental realism signals in the public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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